

THE MARTIN DISABILITY EMPLOYMENT AND SKILLS DEVELOPMENT PROPOSAL

A Disability-Led Workforce Strategy for Alberta

Prepared as a policy submission package for elected officials, disability advocates, community organizations, and public discussion. This document uses verified public statistics where available and clearly labelled estimates where exact program data is not yet public.

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Calgary, Alberta | June 2026

Table of Contents

1. Executive Summary
2. Author Statement
3. Evidence Base and Public Data
4. Problem Definition
5. Policy Objectives
6. Program Design
7. Budget and Cost Scenarios
8. Implementation Plan
9. Accountability Framework
10. Legislative Recommendations
11. Appendices and References

1. Executive Summary

Alberta is entering a new disability policy era through the creation of the Alberta Disability Assistance Program, ADAP. The stated purpose of ADAP is to provide financial, health, personal, and employment supports to Albertans with severe disabilities who are assessed as able to work. The risk is that employment policy may be built around administrative classification rather than practical opportunity.

This proposal argues that if Alberta can create targeted labour pathways for immigration, apprenticeships, sector recruitment, and employer workforce needs, Alberta can also create a dedicated, disability-led employment and training pathway for Albertans already living here.

Core recommendation: Establish the Alberta Disability Employment and Skills Development Program, ADESDP, as a dedicated provincial workforce strategy that protects benefits, funds training, supports employers, creates disability-specific apprenticeships, and gives people with disabilities a real path into work without punishment.

Recommendation	Purpose
Create ADESDP	Build a dedicated employment and skills pathway for Albertans with disabilities.
Protect benefits while working	Prevent people from losing medical, housing, prescription, or personal supports because they try to work.
Fund disability-specific training	Pay for training that matches disability realities, including part-time, remote, supported, and paced learning.
Incentivize employers	Use wage subsidies, tax credits, and accommodation grants to reduce employer risk and increase hiring.
Create oversight	Create an independent Disability Employment Advocate to track outcomes and protect participants.

2. Author Statement

This proposal was created by Devin Martin, an Albertan living with disability and receiving AISH support. It is written from lived experience, not from theory alone. I have pursued education, volunteered in my community, sought employment, and continued trying to contribute despite disability-related barriers that many Albertans face every day.

I am not arguing that every person with a disability can work, nor that disability support should become conditional on employment. I am arguing that people with disabilities who want to work should have a practical, protected, realistic pathway to do so.

A fair disability employment program must recognize fluctuating conditions, pain, mental health, cognitive limitations, transportation barriers, employer bias, fear of benefit loss, and the reality that many people can contribute only when the system is built around stability rather than punishment.

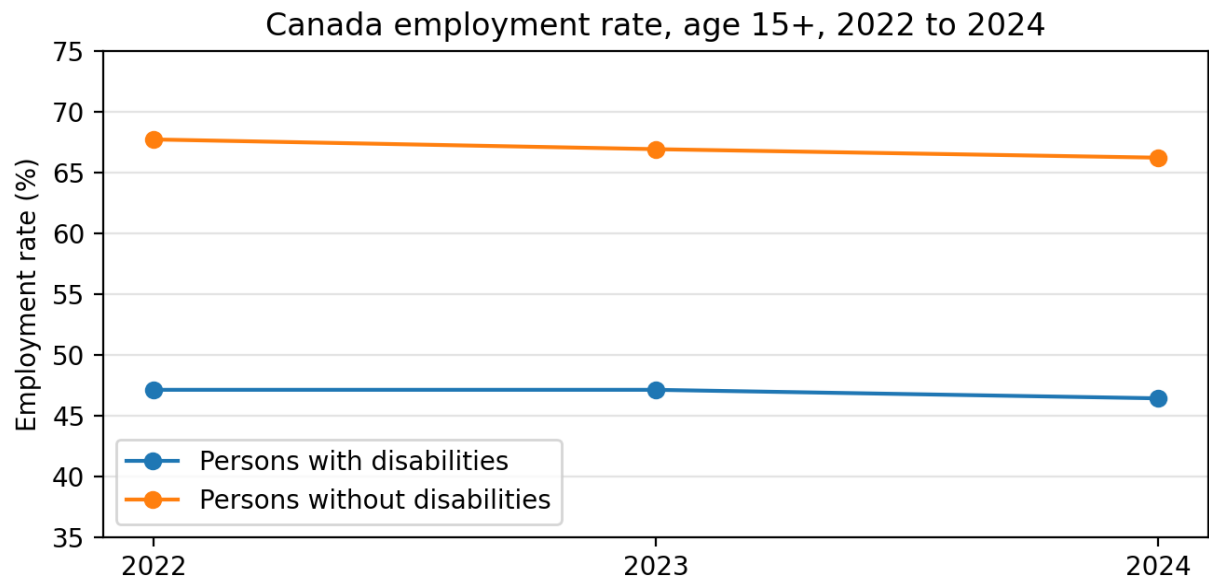
This policy foundation was created by a person on AISH to protect thousands of Albertans with disabilities and to create jobs, training, dignity, and economic participation.

3. Evidence Base and Public Data

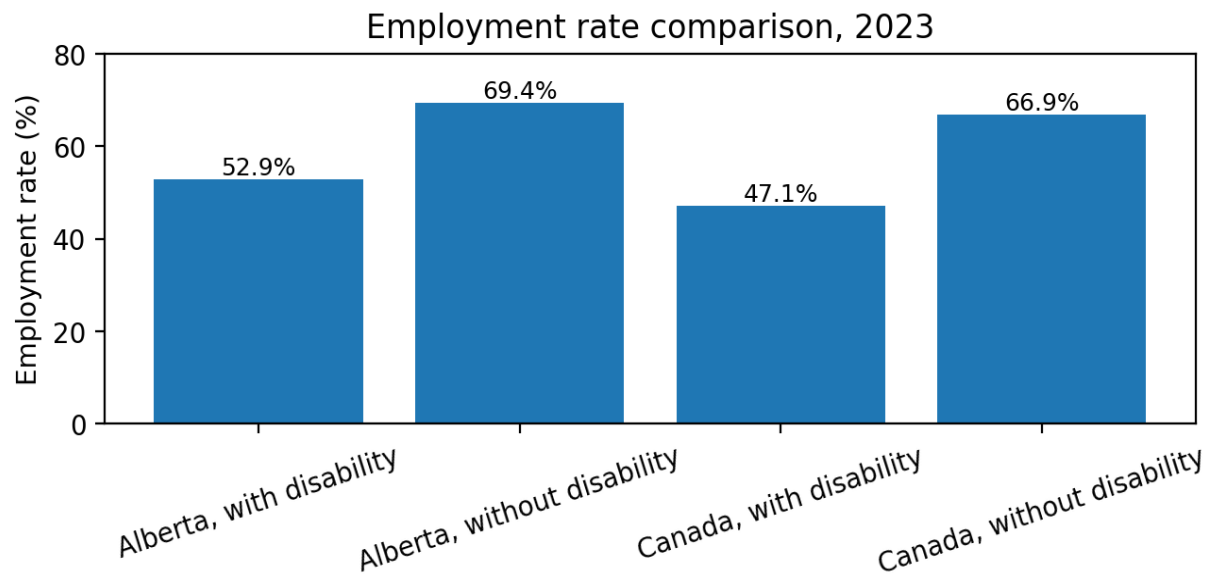
The data below uses public sources from Statistics Canada, Government of Alberta, and Maytree. Where exact future numbers are unknown, the document uses scenario modelling and marks those figures as estimates.

Indicator	Best available data
Canada disability prevalence	In 2022, 27% of Canadians aged 15 and older, nearly 8 million people, reported at least one disability.
Working-age employment gap	In 2022, 62% of persons with disabilities aged 25 to 64 were employed, compared with 78% of persons without disabilities.
Canada employment rate, age 15+	Persons with disabilities were at 47.1% in 2023 and 46.4% in 2024, compared with 66.9% and 66.2% for persons without disabilities.
Alberta employment rate, 2023	Alberta recorded the highest provincial employment rate for persons with disabilities in 2023 at 52.9%, while persons without disabilities were at 69.4%.
AISH caseload, 2024-25	Maytree reports an average of 77,647 AISH cases in Alberta in fiscal year 2024-25.
ADAP launch	Government of Alberta says ADAP becomes operational in July 2026 with a combined application for ADAP and AISH.

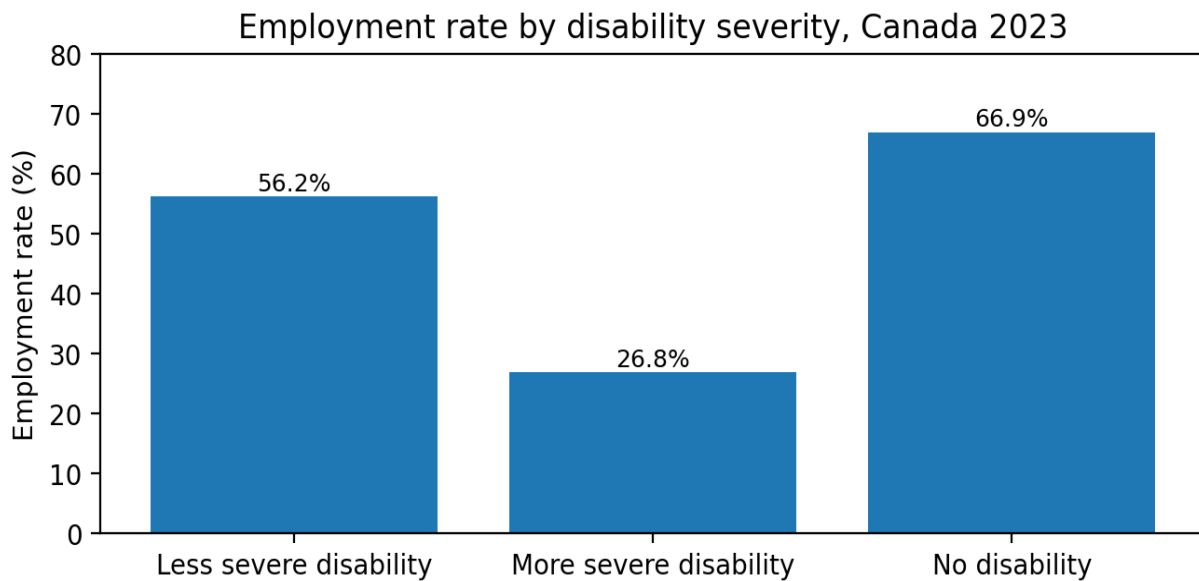
4. Labour Market Charts



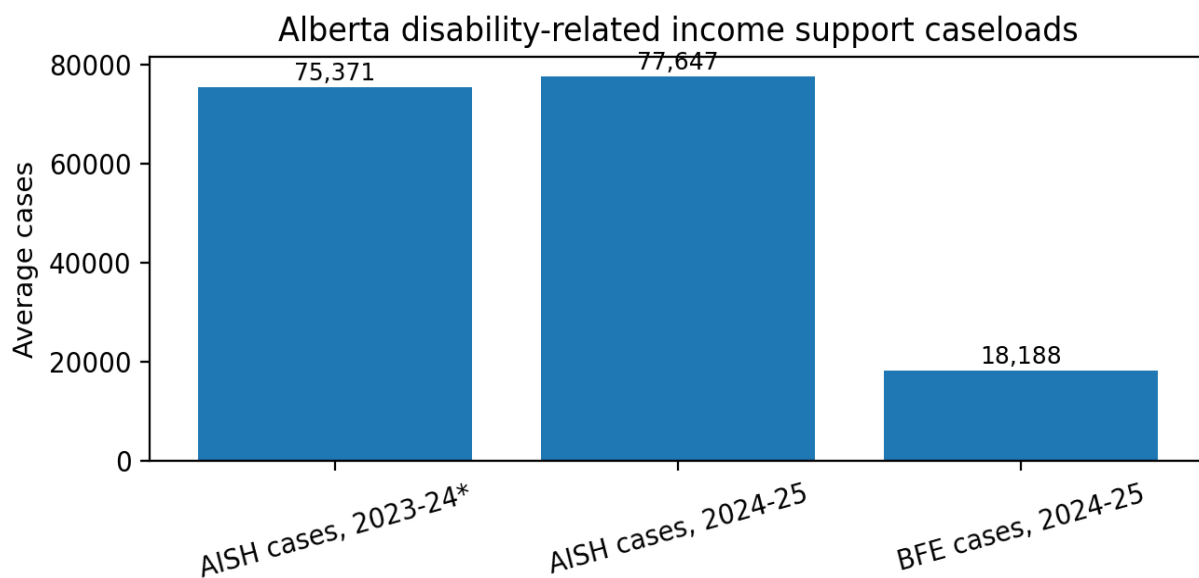
Source: Statistics Canada labour market characteristics, 2023 and 2024. This chart shows that the disability employment gap remains persistent across recent years.



Source: Statistics Canada, 2023. Alberta performed better than the national disability employment rate, but still showed a large gap between disabled and non-disabled Albertans.



Source: Statistics Canada, 2023. Severity matters. A disability employment strategy must not assume all disabilities create the same work capacity.



Source: Maytree, Alberta social assistance summaries, 2024-25. The 2023-24 AISH figure is inferred by subtracting Maytree reported annual increase of 2,276 cases from the 2024-25 average.

5. Problem Definition

The central policy problem is not simply unemployment. It is the absence of a disability-specific workforce pathway that understands disability as a practical employment barrier requiring accommodations, not a character flaw, lack of motivation, or administrative inconvenience.

Barrier	Policy response needed
Fear of losing benefits	Create benefit protection and gradual income transitions.

Barrier	Policy response needed
Employer hesitation	Offer wage subsidies, accommodation grants, and disability hiring support.
Fluctuating capacity	Allow part-time, paced, remote, seasonal, and episodic work models.
Cognitive and memory barriers	Fund coaching, reminders, job aids, assistive technology, and supported employment.
Physical pain and mobility limitations	Prioritize low-impact work, modified duties, remote work, and transportation supports.
Rural isolation	Create remote training, regional partnerships, and transportation funding.

The key design principle is simple: no Albertan should be worse off because they attempted to work.

6. Policy Objectives

The Alberta Disability Employment and Skills Development Program should pursue five objectives.

Objective	Description
Protect dignity	Treat people with disabilities as contributors and citizens, not as problems to be managed.
Create real jobs	Move beyond referral lists and create employer partnerships with measurable placements.
Protect benefits	Ensure health, prescription, assistive device, and personal supports remain secure during employment trials.
Build skills	Fund accessible training connected to actual labour market opportunities.
Measure outcomes	Track employment, retention, earnings, satisfaction, employer participation, and poverty reduction.

7. Proposed Program Design

7.1 Disability Employment Stream

A dedicated employment stream would provide disability-trained employment specialists, individual career plans, employer matching, job coaching, and retention supports. The stream should not be generic job search advice. It should be built for disability realities.

7.2 Disability Skills Training Fund

The training fund should cover tuition, technology, transportation, short certificates, micro-credentials, adaptive equipment, and supported learning. Priority sectors should include administration, digital services, graphic design, community support, peer support, dispatch, customer service, accessibility consulting, bookkeeping, social services support, and entrepreneurship.

7.3 Employer Incentive Program

Employers should receive wage subsidies, accommodation grants, and recognition when they hire and retain workers with disabilities. Incentives should be tied to retention, safe working conditions, and meaningful work, not token hiring.

8. Program Components Continued

7.4 Benefit Protection Guarantee

Participants should keep essential health, prescription, dental, optical, assistive device, and personal supports while attempting employment. Income exemptions and clawback rules must avoid punishing small amounts of work, especially for people with episodic disability.

7.5 Disability Apprenticeship Pathways

Alberta should create flexible apprenticeship-style pathways for disabled workers in fields that can be performed with accommodations. These should include part-time apprenticeships, remote practicums, supported job shadowing, and employer-supervised placements.

7.6 Disability Entrepreneurship Program

Many disabled Albertans may be better suited to self-employment, freelance work, small business, or home-based services. The program should include startup grants, mentorship, procurement access, business coaching, and technology support.

7.7 Independent Disability Employment Advocate

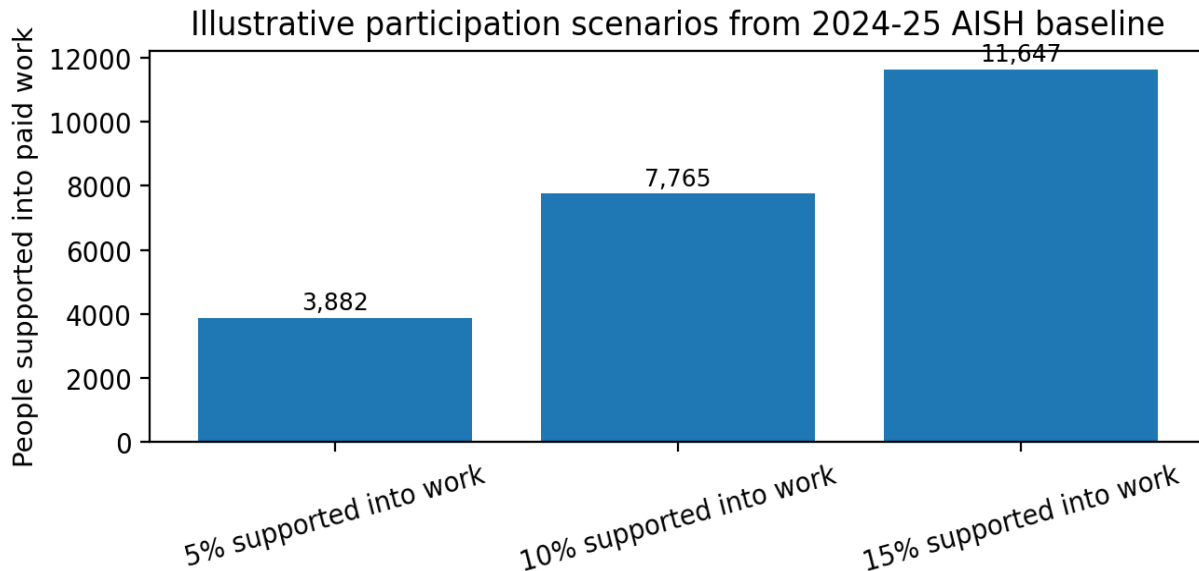
An independent office should monitor outcomes, receive complaints, identify systemic barriers, publish annual reports, and recommend reforms. It should not be buried inside the same bureaucracy responsible for benefit eligibility decisions.

9. Disability Bill of Rights for Employment

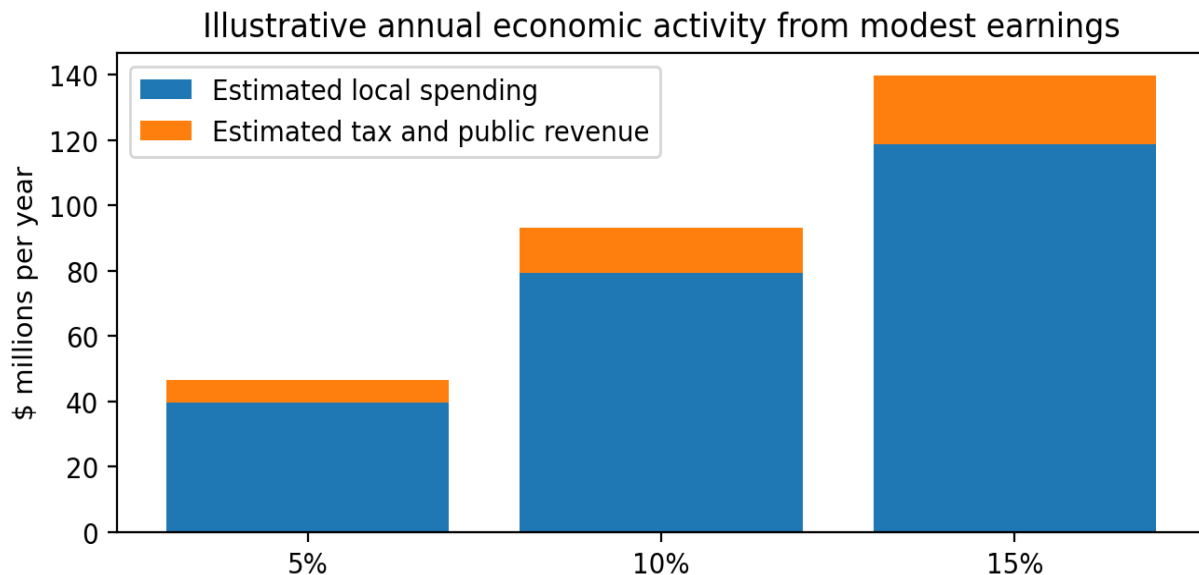
Right	Meaning
Right to dignity	Disability employment policy must not shame, threaten, or punish people for disability.
Right to accommodation	Work and training must be adapted to real limitations.
Right to security	People must not lose essential supports for attempting work.
Right to informed choice	Participation should be individualized and transparent.
Right to appeal	Eligibility, employment, and benefit decisions must have fair review pathways.
Right to opportunity	People with disabilities deserve dedicated pathways equal in seriousness to other workforce programs.

10. Budget and Cost Scenarios

Because final ADAP participation data and administrative costs are not fully known publicly, this section uses scenario modelling. These are not official costings. They are reasonable planning estimates based on the 2024-25 AISH caseload baseline of 77,647 cases reported by Maytree.



Scenario model: If 5%, 10%, or 15% of the 2024-25 AISH baseline were supported into some level of paid work, thousands of Albertans could gain income, experience, and stability. This does not assume full-time work.



Illustrative estimate: assumes supported participants earn an additional \$12,000 per year on average, with 85% circulating as local spending and 15% as rough tax/public revenue impact. These figures are planning estimates, not official projections.

11. Sample Program Budget, Year One Pilot

A serious first-year pilot could begin in Calgary, Edmonton, Lethbridge, Red Deer, Medicine Hat, Grande Prairie, Fort McMurray, and rural/remote virtual delivery. The following is a planning estimate only.

Budget Item	Illustrative Year One Estimate
Program design and consultation	\$1.5 million
Employment specialists and case coordination	\$8.0 million
Training grants and micro-credentials	\$15.0 million
Employer wage subsidies	\$20.0 million
Workplace accommodation grants	\$8.0 million
Entrepreneurship grants	\$5.0 million
Technology and assistive tools	\$4.0 million
Rural and transportation supports	\$4.5 million
Independent oversight and evaluation	\$2.0 million
Total illustrative pilot budget	\$68.0 million

A \$68 million pilot would represent an investment in employment capacity, not merely a social expense. The purpose is to test what works before province-wide expansion.

12. Cost-Benefit Logic

The economic case rests on four forms of return: earned income, local spending, tax contribution, and avoided downstream costs. Downstream costs may include crisis supports, homelessness risk, health deterioration, social isolation, emergency services, and long-term poverty. Exact savings would require government data, but the direction of benefit is clear: better supported employment reduces avoidable instability.

Return area	Expected impact
Earned income	Participants gain wages and work experience.
Local economy	Most low-income earnings are spent locally on rent, food, transportation, and basic needs.
Public revenue	Some earnings return through income tax, payroll deductions, and consumption taxes.
Reduced poverty pressure	Stable income reduces emergency reliance and crisis escalation.

Return area	Expected impact
Better health and dignity	Meaningful work can improve confidence, routine, social connection, and stability.

13. How ADAP Could Be Strengthened

The Government of Alberta states that ADAP will help Albertans with disabilities pursue employment while receiving financial, health, personal, and employment supports. This proposal accepts the stated goal of opportunity but argues that opportunity must be made real through enforceable protections and dedicated infrastructure.

ADAP risk	Recommended safeguard
Classification without enough support	Require individual employment plans with disability accommodations.
Fear of income loss	Guarantee gradual transitions and preserve medical benefits.
Pressure instead of opportunity	Make employment planning supportive, individualized, and non-punitive.
Generic training referrals	Fund disability-specific training and job coaching.
Employer discrimination	Create employer incentives and enforcement through an independent advocate.
Urban-only access	Build rural and remote delivery into program design from the start.

14. Rural Alberta Strategy

A disability employment strategy must not be limited to Calgary and Edmonton. Rural Albertans often face fewer transit options, fewer service providers, limited training access, and fewer disability-friendly employers. The rural strategy should include remote work hubs, mobile employment services, virtual training, local employer partnerships, and transportation supports.

15. Government Leadership

The Government of Alberta should lead by example through targeted disability recruitment in provincial departments, agencies, boards, commissions, and publicly funded organizations. Hiring goals should be transparent, measurable, and tied to accommodation funding.

16. Implementation Plan

Phase	Action
Phase 1, 0 to 6 months	Create advisory table with disabled Albertans, service providers, employers, rural representatives, and disability organizations. Finalize pilot design.
Phase 2, 6 to 18 months	Launch pilots in major cities and rural virtual regions. Begin employer incentives, training grants, and participant supports.
Phase 3, 18 to 36 months	Evaluate outcomes, expand successful models, create legislative protections, and refine benefit rules.
Phase 4, 36 months onward	Province-wide rollout with annual reporting, independent oversight, and continuous improvement.

17. Performance Metrics

Metric	Why it matters
Employment placements	Shows whether the program creates real opportunities.
Job retention at 3, 6, and 12 months	Measures whether jobs are sustainable.
Training completion	Measures skills development.
Participant income growth	Measures financial improvement.
Benefit stability	Ensures people are not harmed by trying to work.
Employer participation	Measures labour market engagement.
Accommodation success	Tracks whether workplace supports actually work.
Participant satisfaction	Ensures disabled Albertans define success, not only administrators.
Appeals and complaints	Identifies systemic barriers.

18. Legislative Recommendations

The Legislature should consider enabling legislation or amendments that create enforceable standards for disability employment support. This does not require replacing AISH or ADAP. It requires adding a dedicated employment and training framework that protects people while building opportunity.

Legislative element	Purpose
Benefit protection clause	Protect medical and personal supports during work attempts.
Accommodation funding authority	Allow grants for adaptive equipment and workplace modifications.
Independent advocate mandate	Create public reporting and complaint review.
Annual reporting requirement	Require published data on outcomes, spending, and participant experience.
Employer incentive authority	Authorize wage subsidies, tax credits, and inclusive hiring grants.
Participant rights statement	Ensure dignity, informed consent, appeals, and non-punitive participation.

19. Formal Resolution

Therefore, I respectfully call upon the Government of Alberta to establish the Alberta Disability Employment and Skills Development Program, ADESDP, and to begin direct consultations with Albertans living with disabilities, AISH and ADAP recipients, employers, disability organizations, service providers, rural communities, and independent advocates.

This proposal should be treated as a disability-led policy foundation. It was created by a person living on AISH to protect the dignity, income security, and workforce potential of thousands of Albertans with disabilities.

20. Executive One-Page Summary for MLAs

Problem: Alberta is creating ADAP, but many disabled Albertans fear that employment expectations may arrive without enough real jobs, training, accommodations, benefit protection, or employer accountability.

Solution: Create a dedicated Alberta Disability Employment and Skills Development Program that gives disabled Albertans the same seriousness of workforce planning that governments already provide to other targeted labour groups.

Core ask: Do not merely move people between benefit categories. Build an actual disability workforce pathway with funding, training, employers, protections, and oversight.

Why it matters: Statistics Canada data shows persistent disability employment gaps. Maytree data shows nearly 78,000 AISH cases on average in 2024-25. Even modest supported employment outcomes could benefit thousands of people and strengthen Alberta communities.

Authorship: This policy foundation was created by Devin Martin, an Albertan on AISH, as a lived-experience proposal to protect disabled Albertans and create opportunity.

Appendix A: Assumptions Used for Guestimation

Assumption	Use in model
Baseline population	77,647 average AISH cases in Alberta in 2024-25, based on Maytree.
Participation scenarios	5%, 10%, and 15% of baseline supported into some paid employment.
Average added earnings	\$12,000 per participant per year, used as modest part-time or flexible employment estimate.
Local spending share	85% of earnings assumed to circulate locally through basic expenses.
Tax/public revenue share	15% rough estimate, used only for illustrative modelling.
Important limitation	The model does not claim all AISH recipients can work, nor does it assume full-time employment. It shows what could happen if supports are voluntary, protected, and practical.

Appendix B: Source Notes

1. Statistics Canada, A demographic, employment and income profile of persons with disabilities aged 15 years and over in Canada, 2022. Key data used: 27% disability prevalence among Canadians aged 15+, nearly 8 million people.
2. Statistics Canada, The Daily, Canadian Survey on Disability, 2017 to 2022. Key data used: 62% employment rate for persons with disabilities aged 25 to 64, compared with 78% for persons without disabilities.
3. Statistics Canada, Labour market characteristics of persons with and without disabilities, 2023. Key data used: Canada 2023 employment rates, Alberta 2023 employment rates, disability severity employment rates, unemployment and wage gap data.
4. Statistics Canada, Labour market characteristics of persons with and without disabilities, 2024. Key data used: 2024 employment rate of persons with disabilities, 46.4%, and persons without disabilities, 66.2%.
5. Maytree, Social Assistance Summaries, Alberta, 2024-25. Key data used: 77,647 average AISH cases in 2024-25, 57,347 Income Support cases, 18,188 BFE cases, 4.3% of Albertans under 65 receiving Income Support or AISH.
6. Government of Alberta, Alberta Disability Assistance Program webpage, accessed June 2026. Key data used: ADAP operational start in July 2026, combined application for ADAP and AISH, ADAP benefit and income exemption descriptions, transition information, and employment support language.

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